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# Strengths Insight and Action-Planning Guide

SURVEY COMPLETION DATE: 01-20-2025



DON CLIFTON

Father of Strengths Psychology and  
Inventor of CliftonStrengths

# Rayan Sebti

SURVEY COMPLETION DATE: 01-20-2025

Depending on the order of your themes and how you responded to the assessment, some of your themes may share identical insight statements. If this occurs, the lower ranked theme will not display insight statements to avoid duplication on your report.

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## Your Top 10 Themes

1. Developer
2. Positivity
3. Woo
4. Self-Assurance
5. Ideation
6. Empathy
7. Input
8. Communication
9. Learner
10. Adaptability

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## What's in This Guide?

### SECTION I: AWARENESS

A brief Shared Theme Description for each of your top ten themes

Your Personalized Strengths Insights, which describe what makes you stand out from others with the same theme in their top ten

Questions for you to answer to increase your awareness of your talents

### SECTION II: APPLICATION

10 Ideas for Action for each of your top ten themes

Questions for you to answer to help you apply your talents

### SECTION III: ACHIEVEMENT

Examples of what each of your top ten themes "sounds like" -- real quotes from people who also have the theme in their top ten

Steps for you to take to help you leverage your talents for achievement

# Section I: Awareness

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## Developer

### SHARED THEME DESCRIPTION

People who are especially talented in the Developer theme recognize and cultivate the potential in others. They spot the signs of each small improvement and derive satisfaction from these improvements.

### YOUR PERSONALIZED STRENGTHS INSIGHTS

#### **What makes you stand out?**

Instinctively, you are tolerant of the mistakes people make when they are learning something new or challenged by a new environment. Your patient observation of their struggles expands your own perspective and helps you see new ways to support them. Driven by your talents, you capture others' attention with your open and talkative style. You support and inspire people. You boost their confidence and support their resolve to respond to change, overcome obstacles, acquire new skills, gain knowledge, or reach lofty goals. By nature, you try to show others that you care. You believe that when you make people feel important, they will be more likely to cooperate with you. Chances are good that you realize numerous individuals need your attention to feel valued or appreciated. Making someone feel special gives you a great deal of satisfaction. You can sense when someone's spirit needs to be lifted or his/her contributions need to be acknowledged. You know what to say and how to say it so your compliments or words of recognition sound truthful, genuine, and sincere. This is one way you nurture relationships with people. Because of your strengths, you are comfortable complimenting individuals you know quite well. After discovering each one's preferences, you can tailor your recognition to fit the person and the situation. You tend to lavish praise on people. You make sure what you say and do pleases rather than embarrasses them. You want the experience to be a good one.

### QUESTIONS

1. As you read your personalized strengths insights, what words, phrases, or lines stand out to you?
2. Out of all the talents in this insight, what would you like for others to see most in you?

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## Positivity

### SHARED THEME DESCRIPTION

People who are especially talented in the Positivity theme have an enthusiasm that is contagious. They are upbeat and can get others excited about what they are going to do.

### YOUR PERSONALIZED STRENGTHS INSIGHTS

#### What makes you stand out?

By nature, you sometimes find life exciting. Maybe you welcome opportunities to accept various types of people into your circle of acquaintances, teammates, family, or friends. Driven by your talents, you seek opportunities to tell others about facts you know or experiences you have had. You allow people to broaden your understanding with their original ideas. You have discovered that “the life of the mind” is a joint effort. You receive from other thinkers as many — and sometimes even more — insights as you provide them. Thinking with individuals or groups stimulates your creativity. You realize it makes each day worth living. Because of your strengths, you start putting things in a sequential order after assessing how all the elements or facts link with one another. By giving of your time and sharing your thoughts, you can help others make good judgments. As a result, projects, processes, or events usually run more smoothly for everyone involved. Using reason and making good judgments, you can make the planning process run smoothly. Instinctively, you frequently take time to figure out what makes a person unique and special. Your keen interest in people explains why many individuals describe you as friendly, thoughtful, kind, likeable, or understanding. Chances are good that you exhibit a genuine fondness for all sorts of people. Newcomers or outsiders intrigue you to such a degree that you start talking with them. You naturally put them at ease with your smile, encouraging words, or compliments.

### QUESTIONS

1. As you read your personalized strengths insights, what words, phrases, or lines stand out to you?
2. Out of all the talents in this insight, what would you like for others to see most in you?

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## Woo

### SHARED THEME DESCRIPTION

People who are especially talented in the Woo theme love the challenge of meeting new people and winning them over. They derive satisfaction from breaking the ice and making a connection with another person.

### YOUR PERSONALIZED STRENGTHS INSIGHTS

#### **What makes you stand out?**

Driven by your talents, you frequently need to know that others appreciate your ability to involve newcomers in discussions. You normally use compliments to acknowledge the talents or successes of those you meet. This prompts many strangers to say, “I’ve heard you are very friendly. Now I know it’s true.” It’s very likely that you have an aptitude for communicating and making conversation. Under very few circumstances do you struggle to find just the right word to express your thoughts or feelings. Being able to put friends or strangers at ease quickly is one of your gifts. By nature, you have a knack for starting discussions with newcomers. You genuinely enjoy the friendly give-and-take as much as the other person does. Even though you are a good talker, you continually search for better ways to keep people’s attention once you have gotten it. Chances are good that you usually are willing to acquire new skills or gain additional knowledge. This explains your eagerness to be the first person to speak with newcomers or outsiders. You undoubtedly sense these individuals can teach you something you need or want to know. Because of your strengths, you are sometimes the person whom team members know best. Perhaps you reveal more information about yourself than some people would feel comfortable sharing.

### QUESTIONS

1. As you read your personalized strengths insights, what words, phrases, or lines stand out to you?
2. Out of all the talents in this insight, what would you like for others to see most in you?

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## Self-Assurance

### SHARED THEME DESCRIPTION

People who are especially talented in the Self-Assurance theme feel confident in their ability to manage their own lives. They possess an inner compass that gives them confidence that their decisions are right.

### YOUR PERSONALIZED STRENGTHS INSIGHTS

#### **What makes you stand out?**

Driven by your talents, you are attracted to volunteer projects, academic courses, or careers that challenge your intellect, skills, talents, and stamina. You trust yourself completely. This explains why you move toward rather than away from important, difficult, or meaningful endeavors. Because of your strengths, you may approach certain win-lose situations in a practical and realistic manner. When you are intent on being victorious, perhaps you extinguish any sentimental feelings you might have toward your rivals. It's very likely that you periodically test whether a concept or plan is really workable. How? You might discuss it with some of your coworkers, classmates, or teammates. Perhaps your ideas become sharper each time you are asked to explain your reasoning. By nature, you want many individuals to follow you. You hope they automatically regard you as the person in charge. After your results are compared to the outcomes of others, you want it to be clear to them that you are the very best. This probably is reason enough for them to give you their full allegiance. Instinctively, you customarily facilitate the group's conversation. You carry yourself with an air of distinction. You take charge quite naturally. Nevertheless you appreciate the willingness of people to openly exchange ideas.

### QUESTIONS

1. As you read your personalized strengths insights, what words, phrases, or lines stand out to you?
2. Out of all the talents in this insight, what would you like for others to see most in you?

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## Ideation

### SHARED THEME DESCRIPTION

People who are especially talented in the Ideation theme are fascinated by ideas. They are able to find connections between seemingly disparate phenomena.

### YOUR PERSONALIZED STRENGTHS INSIGHTS

#### **What makes you stand out?**

Driven by your talents, you often opt to work separately from others. Even so, you probably are quite sensitive about what people think of your contributions, accomplishments, talents, limitations, or other traits. Chances are good that you thoroughly examine the idiosyncrasies, interests, talents, successes, fears, or dreams of each person you encounter. You contend that no two people are the same. You argue that the same individual reacts quite differently depending on the circumstances and the human beings present. People simply fascinate you. By nature, you enjoy being well-read. Not surprisingly, you can introduce more questions, suggestions, solutions, or innovative ideas into group conversations than most participants can. Instinctively, you are ecstatic — that is, thrilled — when you read about a novel concept or an original theory. Probably, the hope of discovering a new way of thinking motivates you to read a lot. You enjoy collecting a variety of information. You sense that one day you will find a proper use for it. It's very likely that you enjoy reading, but you refrain from accepting information on its face value — that is, its seeming worth or truth. Typically you examine ideas, suggestions, or facts from a variety of angles. Only then do you judge what is worth filing away, taking notes on, or remembering for later reference.

### QUESTIONS

1. As you read your personalized strengths insights, what words, phrases, or lines stand out to you?
2. Out of all the talents in this insight, what would you like for others to see most in you?



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## Empathy

### SHARED THEME DESCRIPTION

People who are especially talented in the Empathy theme can sense the feelings of other people by imagining themselves in others' lives or others' situations.

### YOUR PERSONALIZED STRENGTHS INSIGHTS

#### **What makes you stand out?**

By nature, you occasionally know if you have or have not won the approval of a particular person or group. You might harbor a deep-seated yearning to belong. You may be delighted if numerous individuals welcome you into their lives. Because of your strengths, you occasionally choose to distance yourself from bold, aggressive, or domineering individuals. Perhaps their words and nonverbal forcefulness make you feel uncomfortable. Chances are good that you may be a person who feels certain things very deeply. This partially explains why you place some importance on having others know who you are as a person or as a professional. Perhaps you hope specific individuals grasp a little bit of what you think, feel, need, dream, or desire. It's very likely that you know you spotlight the best ideas people share with you. By giving your full attention to another person, you acknowledge the value of his or her thoughts and feelings. In the process, you usually enhance the individual's confidence. Driven by your talents, you sometimes amuse people with stories, examples, or playful capers. Perhaps your style of delivery distracts certain individuals from the mundane or numbing routines of their lives. Maybe you know what to say and how to say it. Why? It might be because you are aware of various human emotions.

### QUESTIONS

1. As you read your personalized strengths insights, what words, phrases, or lines stand out to you?
2. Out of all the talents in this insight, what would you like for others to see most in you?

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## Input

### SHARED THEME DESCRIPTION

People who are especially talented in the Input theme have a craving to know more. Often they like to collect and archive all kinds of information.

### YOUR PERSONALIZED STRENGTHS INSIGHTS

#### **What makes you stand out?**

By nature, you attempt to gauge how much information you have acquired compared to the amount someone else has gathered. Your rivalries may be actual or merely contests you have conceived in your mind. You might be motivated to accumulate additional knowledge to increase your advantage over specific individuals. Moreover, you might want to be acclaimed as the smartest or most informed person in a particular group. Instinctively, you are fascinated with the written word. Books, magazines, newspapers, correspondence and websites intrigue you. Whether you choose fiction or nonfiction, you enjoy facts and insights into human behavior. Ordinary and extraordinary experiences, philosophies of life, and research findings captivate you as well. Guided by your unique interests, you regularly add to your storehouse of knowledge whenever you read. Chances are good that you revel in having time alone to read. You probably search through books, publications, documents, or the Internet to find information you can use to organize things for people. The facts and insights you gain frequently enable you to coordinate activities such as trips, special events, or work-related projects. Driven by your talents, you may be a history buff — that is, someone who enjoys studying the past. Once in a while, you are drawn to firsthand accounts of global conflicts. You attempt to link specific people to certain events. Occasionally you trace timelines to broaden your knowledge. Perhaps you examine some of the major battles from the perspective of foes, allies, or neutral parties. The sum of your findings might allow you to determine what started or eventually ended each war. Because of your strengths, you sometimes read specific books, journals, blogs or websites. Perhaps you enjoy collecting certain types of information and insights. You may draw on what you read weeks, months or even years ago to outmaneuver individuals whose performance is being compared to yours.

### QUESTIONS

1. As you read your personalized strengths insights, what words, phrases, or lines stand out to you?
2. Out of all the talents in this insight, what would you like for others to see most in you?

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## Communication

### SHARED THEME DESCRIPTION

People who are especially talented in the Communication theme generally find it easy to put their thoughts into words. They are good conversationalists and presenters.

### YOUR PERSONALIZED STRENGTHS INSIGHTS

#### **What makes you stand out?**

It's very likely that you communicate with others easily. You might even enjoy opportunities to debate with others because of your ability to think quickly and to see different pathways. Chances are good that you sometimes enjoy amusing people. Perhaps you are happiest about life when you can put individuals in a good mood. You might tell a few stories or jokes. You might offer compliments. Instinctively, you have a gift for engaging people in group conversations. You also are an active participant. Your upbeat attitude energizes the dialogue. You acknowledge the ideas people share. You reinforce the value of what they say. Consequently, many people become even more willing to reveal their thoughts and feelings. By nature, you occasionally demonstrate an ease with language. Sometimes you effortlessly verbalize your thoughts. You might delight in the opportunity to share your insights. Maybe you derive exceptional pleasure from actively participating in conversations as long as group members propose ideas, seek solutions, or debate issues. Because of your strengths, you easily enter into dialogue with others. When you have an idea, the right words, stories, or examples quickly come to mind. The animated give-and-take of debates stimulates your thinking. Often you gain the advantage by emphasizing irrefutable — that is, cannot be disproved — facts to support your key arguments. Victory for you means having the final word.

### QUESTIONS

1. As you read your personalized strengths insights, what words, phrases, or lines stand out to you?
2. Out of all the talents in this insight, what would you like for others to see most in you?

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## Learner

### SHARED THEME DESCRIPTION

People who are especially talented in the Learner theme have a great desire to learn and want to continuously improve. In particular, the process of learning, rather than the outcome, excites them.

### YOUR PERSONALIZED STRENGTHS INSIGHTS

#### What makes you stand out?

It's very likely that you automatically isolate the basic elements of an intriguing project, the fundamental features of a fascinating product, or the key facts about a novel concept. When you are interested in something, you tend to give it your full attention for hours, days, weeks, months, or even years. The process of acquiring knowledge gives you much satisfaction. Chances are good that you may be attracted to assignments that demand original and inventive thinking. In some cases, you track down new ideas, facts, or data. Your out-of-the-box thinking might challenge some people to abandon, or at the very least to question, specific conventional practices. When you cause one or two of them to suggest options, maybe their need to protect the status quo will be replaced by a desire to gather more information. Driven by your talents, you center your efforts on making improvements that you decide are intriguing and relevant to your life. You devote a great deal of time and energy to acquiring the knowledge and skills that you sense you lack. You regularly challenge yourself to address your shortcomings. Instinctively, you might go through life gleaning bits of information to add to your storehouse of knowledge. Perhaps this partially satisfies your need to expand your thinking as well as broaden your skills. Rarely a stranger to hard work and long hours, you attempt to reinforce your grasp of a subject by reading, studying, discussing, or writing about it. From time to time, you may practice honing — that is, sharpening — a particular ability. Because of your strengths, you might feel discontent when you can't acquire knowledge of a historical nature. This partially explains why you seek the company of people who are students of the past. You may enjoy conversing with them, asking questions or listening to their stories. To some degree, individuals who have lived through momentous times or who have experienced unparalleled changes in politics, science, economics or entertainment intrigue you.

### QUESTIONS

1. As you read your personalized strengths insights, what words, phrases, or lines stand out to you?
2. Out of all the talents in this insight, what would you like for others to see most in you?

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## Adaptability

### SHARED THEME DESCRIPTION

People who are especially talented in the Adaptability theme prefer to “go with the flow.” They tend to be “now” people who take things as they come and discover the future one day at a time.

### YOUR PERSONALIZED STRENGTHS INSIGHTS

#### What makes you stand out?

Instinctively, you might feel drawn to disorder. While some crave order, you aren’t afraid to embrace confusion and respond to disarray. Managing a messy day can help calm the chaos and lead to good outcomes. By nature, you now and then set aside time to appreciate the loveliness and splendor of your surroundings. It’s very likely that you typically wait for difficult situations or problems to arise. When something or someone unexpectedly blocks your progress, you probably find ways to do things better. Sudden changes force you to consider upgrades or tactics you had not thought of earlier. Because of your strengths, you exhibit a certain degree of awareness about the beauty surrounding you. Sometimes you even pause to consider all the loveliness you can see, touch, hear, smell, or taste. Driven by your talents, you might labor tirelessly on whatever needs to be accomplished today. Perhaps you are willing to change some of your plans when certain people change theirs. To some degree, you remain calm when others reverse their decisions, modify their schedules, or cancel their appointments.

### QUESTIONS

1. As you read your personalized strengths insights, what words, phrases, or lines stand out to you?
2. Out of all the talents in this insight, what would you like for others to see most in you?

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## Questions

1. How does this information help you better understand your unique talents?
2. How can you use this understanding to add value to your role?
3. How can you apply this knowledge to add value to your team, workgroup, department, or division?
4. How will this understanding help you add value to your organization?
5. What will you do differently tomorrow as a result of this report?

## Section II: Application

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### Developer

#### IDEAS FOR ACTION

Make a list of the people you have helped learn and grow. Look at the list often, and remind yourself of the effect you have had on the world.

Seek roles in which your primary responsibilities include facilitating growth. Teaching, coaching, or managing roles might prove especially satisfying for you.

Notice when others succeed, and tell them. Be specific about what you saw. Your detailed observations of what led to their victory will enhance their growth.

Identify the mentor or mentors who recognized something special inside you. Take the time to thank them for helping you develop, even if this means tracking down a former schoolteacher and sending him or her a letter.

Partner with someone with strong Individualization talents. This person can help you see where each person's greatest talents lie. Without this help, your Developer instincts might lead you to encourage people to grow in areas in which they lack real talent.

Carefully avoid supporting someone who is consistently struggling in his or her role. In such instances, the most developmental action you can take is to encourage him or her to find a different role — a role that fits.

You will always be compelled to mentor more people than is possible. To fulfill this inner drive while maintaining a primary mentoring focus, consider the impact of being a “mentor for the moment.” Many of the most poignant and memorable developmental moments occur when the right words are delivered at the right time — words that clarify understanding, reignite a passion, open eyes to an opportunity, and change a life course.

Don't over-invest in losing causes. Your natural inclination to see the best in people and situations can create a blind spot that will keep you from moving on to more opportune situations.

Your Developer talents might lead you to become so invested in the growth of others that you ignore your own development. Remember that you cannot give what you do not have. If you want to have a bigger impact on the well-being and growth of others, you need to keep growing yourself. Find a mentor or coach who can invest in you.

Make a list of the people you would like to help develop. Write what you would consider to be each person's strengths. Schedule time to meet with each of them regularly — even if for only 15 minutes — and make a point of discussing their goals and their strengths.

## QUESTIONS

1. Which of these action items speak to you? Highlight the actions that you are most likely to take.
2. How will you commit to taking action? Write your own personalized action item that you will take in the next 30 days.

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## Positivity

### IDEAS FOR ACTION

You probably will excel in any role in which you are paid to highlight the positive. A teaching role, a sales role, an entrepreneurial role, or a leadership role will make the most of your ability to make things dramatic.

You tend to be more enthusiastic and energetic than most people. When others become discouraged or are reluctant to take risks, your attitude will provide the impetus to keep them moving. Over time, others will start to look to you for this “lift.”

Plan highlight activities for your friends and colleagues. For example, find ways to turn small achievements into events, plan regular celebrations that others can look forward to, or capitalize on the year's holidays and festivals.

Explain that your enthusiasm is not simple naivety. You know that bad things can happen; you simply prefer to focus on the good things.

You may get your greatest joy by encouraging people. Freely show your appreciation of others, and make sure that the praise is not vague. Consistently seek to translate your feelings into specific, tangible, and personal expressions of gratitude and recognition.

As you share your Positivity talents, be sure to protect and nurture them. As necessary, insulate yourself from chronic whiners and complainers, and intentionally spend time in highly positive environments that will invigorate and feed your optimism.

Don't pretend that difficulties don't concern you. Other people need to know that while you find the good in virtually every situation, you are not naïve. Recognize challenges, and communicate the reasons for your optimism. Your positive approach will be most powerful when others realize it is grounded in reality.



Because people will rely on you to help them rise above their daily frustrations, arm yourself with good stories, jokes, and sayings. Never underestimate the effect that you can have on people.

Avoid negative people. They will bring you down. Instead, seek people who find the same kind of drama and humor in the world that you do. You will energize each other.

Deliberately help others see the things that are going well for them. You can keep their eyes on the positive.

## QUESTIONS

1. Which of these action items speak to you? Highlight the actions that you are most likely to take.
  2. How will you commit to taking action? Write your own personalized action item that you will take in the next 30 days.
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## Woo

### IDEAS FOR ACTION

Choose a job in which you can interact with many people over the course of a day.

Deliberately build the network of people who know you. Tend to it by checking in with each person at least once a month.

Join local organizations, volunteer for committees, and find out how to get on the social lists of the influential people where you live.

Learn the names of as many people as you can. Create a file of the people you know, and add names as you become acquainted. Include a snippet of personal information — such as their birthday, favorite color, hobby, or favorite sports team.

In social situations, take responsibility for helping put reserved people at ease.

Find the right words to explain that networking is part of your style. If you don't claim this theme, others might mistake it for insincerity and wonder why you are being so friendly.

Partner with someone with dominant Relator or Empathy talents. This person can solidify the relationships that you begin.

Your Woo talents give you the ability to quicken the pulse of your surroundings. Recognize the power of your presence and how you open doors for an exchange of ideas. By simply starting conversations that engage others and bring talented people together, you will take performance up a notch — or several.

The first moments of any social occasion are crucial to how comfortable people will be and how they will remember the event. Whenever possible, be one of the first people others meet. Your capacity for meeting and greeting new people will help to quickly put them at ease.

Practice ways to charm and engage others. For example, research people before you meet them so you can talk about your common interests.

## QUESTIONS

1. Which of these action items speak to you? Highlight the actions that you are most likely to take.
2. How will you commit to taking action? Write your own personalized action item that you will take in the next 30 days.

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## Self-Assurance

### IDEAS FOR ACTION

Look for start-up situations for which no rulebook exists. You will be at your best when you are asked to make many decisions.

Seek roles in which you convince people to see your point of view. Your Self-Assurance talents (especially when combined with Command or Activator talents) can be extremely persuasive. Leadership, sales, legal, or entrepreneurial roles might suit you.

Let your self-confidence show. It can be contagious and will help the people around you grow.

Realize that sometimes you will find it hard to put your certainty or intuition into words, possibly leading others to see you as self-righteous. Explain that your confidence does not mean that they should withhold their opinions. It might not seem like it to them, but you do want to hear their ideas. Your conviction doesn't mean that you are unwilling to listen to them.

Your independent streak can leave you standing alone. If this happens, make sure you are out in front, or partner with someone who can help others see how they can benefit from following you.

Partner with someone with strong Strategic, Deliberative, or Futuristic talents. This person can help you

assess the goals to which you commit. You need this help because once you set your sights on a goal, you are likely to stay with it until you achieve it.

Your exceptionally hard work and long hours are natural products of the passion and confidence you feel about your work. Don't assume that others are similarly wired.

You can be decisive, even when things get dynamic and distracting. When there is chaos around you, intentionally display and share the calm and certainty within you. This will give others comfort and security.

Set ambitious goals. Don't hesitate to reach for what others see as impractical and impossible, but what you see as merely bold and exciting — and most importantly — achievable with some heroics and a little luck. Your Self-Assurance talents can lead to achievements that you may not have otherwise even imagined.

You don't have a great need for direction and support from others. This could make you particularly effective in situations that require independent thinking and action. Recognize and actively contribute the value of your Self-Assurance talents when confidence and self-control are crucial.

## QUESTIONS

1. Which of these action items speak to you? Highlight the actions that you are most likely to take.
2. How will you commit to taking action? Write your own personalized action item that you will take in the next 30 days.

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## Ideation

### IDEAS FOR ACTION

Seek a career in which you will be given credit for and paid for your ideas, such as marketing, advertising, journalism, design, or new product development.

You are likely to get bored quickly, so make some small changes in your work or home life. Experiment. Play mental games with yourself. All of these will help keep you stimulated.

Finish your thoughts and ideas before communicating them. Lacking your Ideation talents, others might not be able to “join the dots” of an interesting but incomplete idea and thus might dismiss it.

Not all your ideas will be equally practical or serviceable. Learn to edit your ideas, or find a trusted friend or colleague who can “proof” your ideas and identify potential pitfalls.

Understand the fuel for your Ideation talents: When do you get your best ideas? When you're talking with people? When you're reading? When you're simply listening or observing? Take note of the circumstances that seem to produce your best ideas, and recreate them.

Schedule time to read, because the ideas and experiences of others can become your raw material for new ideas. Schedule time to think, because thinking energizes you.

You are a natural fit with research and development; you appreciate the mindset of visionaries and dreamers. Spend time with imaginative peers, and sit in on their brainstorming sessions.

Partner with someone with strong Analytical talents. This person will question you and challenge you, therefore strengthening your ideas.

Sometimes you lose others' interest because they cannot follow your abstract and conceptual thinking style. Make your ideas more concrete by drawing pictures, using analogies or metaphors, or simply explaining your concepts step by step.

Feed your Ideation talents by gathering knowledge. Study fields and industries different from your own. Apply ideas from outside, and link disparate ideas to generate new ones.

## QUESTIONS

1. Which of these action items speak to you? Highlight the actions that you are most likely to take.
2. How will you commit to taking action? Write your own personalized action item that you will take in the next 30 days.

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## Empathy

### IDEAS FOR ACTION

Help your friends and colleagues be more aware when one of your peers is having a difficult time. Remember, most people do not have your ability to pick up on sensitive situations.

Act quickly and firmly when others behave in a way that is unhealthy for themselves or others. Understanding someone's emotional state does not mean that you must excuse this behavior. Be aware that when your empathy turns to sympathy, others might see you as a "bleeding heart."

Partner with someone with strong Command or Activator talents. This person will help you take needed action, even though people's feelings might suffer as a result.

Consider serving others as a confidante or mentor. Because trust is paramount to you, people are likely to feel comfortable approaching you with any need. Your discretion and desire to be genuinely helpful will be greatly valued.

At times, your empathy for others may overwhelm you. Create some rituals that you can use at the end of your day to signal that work is over. This will help buffer your emotions and prevent burnout.

Identify a friend who has strong Empathy talents, and check your observations with him or her.

Sensitive to the feelings of others, you readily gauge the emotional tone of a room. Use your talents to forge a bridge of understanding and mutual support. Your empathy will be especially important during trying times because it will demonstrate your concern, thereby building loyalty.

Witnessing the happiness of others brings you pleasure. Consequently, you are likely to be attuned to opportunities to underscore others' successes and positively reinforce their achievements. At each opportunity, deliver a kind word of appreciation or recognition. In doing so, you are likely to make a profound and engaging impression.

Because you are observant of how others are feeling, you are likely to intuit what is about to happen before it becomes common knowledge. Although your intuitions may at times seem nothing more than 'hunches', take conscious note of them. They may turn out to be valuable assets.

Sometimes empathy does not require words at all. A kind gesture may be all someone needs to be reassured. Use your Empathy talents to nonverbally comfort others with a glance, a smile, or a pat on the arm.

## QUESTIONS

1. Which of these action items speak to you? Highlight the actions that you are most likely to take.
2. How will you commit to taking action? Write your own personalized action item that you will take in the next 30 days.

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## Input

### IDEAS FOR ACTION

Look for jobs in which you are charged with acquiring new information each day, such as teaching, research, or journalism.

Devise a system to store and easily locate information. This can be as simple as a file for all the articles you have clipped or as sophisticated as a computer database.

Partner with someone with dominant Focus or Discipline talents. This person will help you stay on track when your inquisitiveness leads you down intriguing but distracting avenues.

Your mind is open and absorbent. You naturally soak up information in the same way that a sponge soaks up water. But just as the primary purpose of the sponge is not to permanently contain what it absorbs, neither should your mind simply store information. Input without output can lead to stagnation. As you gather and absorb information, be aware of the individuals and groups that can most benefit from your knowledge, and be intentional about sharing with them.

You might naturally be an exceptional repository of facts, data, and ideas. If that's the case, don't be afraid to position yourself as an expert. By simply following your Input talents, you could become known as the authority in your field.

Remember that you must be more than just a collector of information. At some point, you'll need to leverage this knowledge and turn it into action. Make a point of identifying the facts and data that would be most valuable to others, and use this information to their advantage.

Identify your areas of specialization, and actively seek more information about them.

Schedule time to read books and articles that stimulate you.

Deliberately increase your vocabulary. Collect new words, and learn the meaning of each of them.

Identify situations in which you can share the information you have collected with other people. Also make sure to let your friends and colleagues know that you enjoy answering their questions.

## QUESTIONS

1. Which of these action items speak to you? Highlight the actions that you are most likely to take.
2. How will you commit to taking action? Write your own personalized action item that you will take in the next 30 days.

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## Communication

### IDEAS FOR ACTION

You will always do well in roles that require you to capture people's attention. Think about a career in teaching, sales, marketing, ministry, or the media. Your Communication talents are likely to flourish in these areas.

Start a collection of stories or phrases that resonate with you. For example, cut out magazine articles that move you, or write down powerful word combinations. Practice telling these stories or saying these words out loud, by yourself. Listen to yourself actually saying the words. Refine.

When you are presenting, pay close attention to your audience. Watch their reactions to each part of your presentation. You will notice that some parts are especially engaging. Afterwards, take time to identify the moments that particularly caught the audience's attention. Draft your next presentation around these highlights.

Practice. Improvisation has a certain appeal, but in general, an audience will respond best to a presenter who knows where he or she is headed. Counterintuitively, the more prepared you are, the more natural your improvisations will appear.

Identify your most beneficial sounding boards and audiences — the listeners who seem to bring out your best communication. Examine these individuals or groups to learn why you are so good when you speak with them or to them, and look for the same qualities in potential partners and audiences.

Keep getting smarter about the words you use. They are a critical currency. Spend them wisely, and monitor their impact.

Your Communication talents can be highly effective when your message has substance. Don't rely on your talents alone; take your communication to the level of strength by developing your knowledge and expertise in specific areas.

You are gifted in fostering dialogue among peers and colleagues. Use your Communication talents to summarize the various points in a meeting and to build consensus by helping others see what they have in common.

If you enjoy writing, consider publishing your work. If you enjoy public speaking, make a presentation at a professional meeting or convention. In either case, your Communication talents will serve to assist you in finding just the right way to frame your ideas and state your purpose. You delight in sharing your thoughts with others, so find the medium that best fits your voice and message.

Volunteer for opportunities to present. You can become known as someone who helps people express their thoughts and ambitions in a captivating way.

## QUESTIONS

1. Which of these action items speak to you? Highlight the actions that you are most likely to take.
2. How will you commit to taking action? Write your own personalized action item that you will take in the next 30 days.

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## Learner

### IDEAS FOR ACTION

Refine how you learn. For example, you might learn best by teaching; if so, seek out opportunities to present to others. You might learn best through quiet reflection; if so, find this quiet time.

Develop ways to track the progress of your learning. If there are distinct levels or stages of learning within a discipline or skill, take a moment to celebrate your progression from one level to the next. If no such levels exist, create them for yourself (e.g., reading five books on the subject or making three presentations on the subject).

Be a catalyst for change. Others might be intimidated by new rules, new skills, or new circumstances. Your willingness to soak up this newness can calm their fears and spur them to action. Take this responsibility seriously.

Seek roles that require some form of technical competence. You will enjoy the process of acquiring and maintaining this expertise.

As far as possible, shift your career toward a field with constantly changing technologies or regulations. You will be energized by the challenge of keeping up.

Because you are not threatened by unfamiliar information, you might excel in a consulting role (either internal or external) in which you are paid to go into new situations and pick up new competencies or languages quickly.

Research supports the link between learning and performance. When people have the opportunity to learn and grow, they are more productive and loyal. Look for ways to measure the degree to which you and others feel that your learning needs are being met, to create individualized learning milestones, and to reward achievements in learning.



At work, take advantage of programs that subsidize your learning. Your organization may be willing to pay for part or all of your instructional coursework or for certifications. Ask your manager for information about scholarships and other educational opportunities.

Honor your desire to learn. Take advantage of adult educational opportunities in your community. Discipline yourself to sign up for at least one new academic or adult learning course each year.

Time disappears and your attention intensifies when you are immersed in studying or learning. Allow yourself to “follow the trail” by scheduling learning sessions during periods of time that will not be interrupted by pressing engagements.

## QUESTIONS

1. Which of these action items speak to you? Highlight the actions that you are most likely to take.
2. How will you commit to taking action? Write your own personalized action item that you will take in the next 30 days.

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## Adaptability

### IDEAS FOR ACTION

Cultivate your reputation as a calm and reassuring person when others become upset by daily events.

Avoid roles that demand structure and predictability. These roles will quickly frustrate you, make you feel inadequate, and stifle your independence.

When the pressure is on, help your hesitant friends, colleagues, and clients find ways to collect themselves and take control of the situation. Explain that adaptability is about more than simply rolling with the punches; it is about calmly, intelligently, and readily responding to circumstances.

Don't let others abuse your inherent flexibility. Though your Adaptability talents serve you well, don't compromise your long-term success by bending to every whim, desire, and demand of others. Use smart guidelines to help you decide when to flex and when to stand firm.

Seek roles in which success depends on responding to constantly changing circumstances. Consider career areas such as journalism, live television production, emergency healthcare, and customer service. In these roles, the best react the fastest and stay levelheaded.

Fine-tune your responsiveness. For example, if your job demands unanticipated travel, learn how to pack

and leave in 30 minutes. If your work pressure comes in unpredictable spurts, practice the first three moves you will always make when the pressure hits.

Look to others for planning. People who have strong Focus, Strategic, or Belief talents can help you shape your long-term goals, leaving you to excel at dealing with the day-to-day variations.

Your Adaptability talents give you an even-keel mindset that lets you ride the ups and downs without becoming an emotional volcano. Your “don’t cry over spilled milk” approach will help you quickly recover from setbacks. Recognize this aspect of your nature, and help your friends and colleagues understand that it is productive flexibility rather than an “I don’t care” attitude.

Avoid tasks that are too structured and stifle your need for variety. If given a list of tasks to complete, try to indulge your desire for flexibility by making a game of that list. See if you can be creative or make the tasks more fun in some way.

Openly use your reassuring demeanor to soothe disgruntled friends or coworkers. Think about the approach you used, and remember to apply it again when the situation presents itself.

## QUESTIONS

1. Which of these action items speak to you? Highlight the actions that you are most likely to take.
2. How will you commit to taking action? Write your own personalized action item that you will take in the next 30 days.

## Section III: Achievement

Look for signs of achievement as you read these real quotes from people who share your top ten themes.

### DEVELOPER SOUNDS LIKE THIS:

Marilyn K., college president: “At graduation time when a nursing student walks across the stage and gets her diploma, and about 18 rows back some little kid is standing on a chair with a group yelling, ‘Yeah, Mom!’ — I love that. I cry every time.”

John M., advertising executive: “I’m not a lawyer, doctor, or candlestick maker. My skills are of a different type. They have to do with understanding people and motives, and the pleasure I get is from watching people discover themselves in ways they never thought possible and from finding people who bring to the table talents that I don’t have.”

Anna G., nurse: “I had a patient, a young woman, with lung damage so bad that she will have to be on oxygen forever. She will never have the energy or the strength to live a normal life, and I walk in and she’s desperate. She doesn’t know if she is short of breath because she is anxious or anxious because she is short of breath. And she’s talking suicide because she can’t work, can’t support her husband. So I got her thinking about what she could do rather than what she couldn’t. It turns out that she is very creative with arts and crafts, so I told her, ‘Look, there are things you can do, and if those things bring you pleasure, then do them. It’s a place to start.’ And she cried and said, ‘I have the energy to wash only one bowl.’ I said, ‘That’s today. Tomorrow you can wash two.’ And by Christmas, she was making all kinds of things and selling them too.”

### POSITIVITY SOUNDS LIKE THIS:

Gerry L., flight attendant: “There are so many people on an airplane that I have made it a point over the years to single out one or two on a flight and make it something special for them. Certainly, I will be courteous to everybody and extend to them the kind of professionalism that I would like given to me, but over and above that, I try to make one person or family or small group of people feel particularly special, with jokes and conversation and little games that I play.”

Andy B., Internet marketing executive: “I am one of those people who loves creating buzz. I read magazines all the time, and if I find something fun — some new store, new lip gloss, whatever — I will charge around telling everyone about it. ‘Oh, you just have to try this store. It is so-o-o cool. Look at these pictures. Check them out.’ I am so passionate when I talk about something that people just have to do what I say. It’s not that I am a great salesperson. I’m not. In fact, I hate asking for the close; I hate bothering people. It’s just that my passion about what I say makes people think, ‘Gosh, it must be true.’”

Sunny G., communications manager: “I think the world is plagued with enough negative people. We need more positive people — people who like to zero in on what is right with the world. Negative people just make me feel heavy. In my last job, there was a guy who came into my office every morning just to unload on me. I would purposely dodge him. I’d see him coming, and I’d run to the bathroom or go some other place. He made me feel as if the world was a miserable place, and I hated that.”

#### WOO SOUNDS LIKE THIS:

Deborah C., publishing executive: “I have made best friends out of people that I have met passing in the doorway. I mean, it’s awful, but wooing is part of who I am. All my taxi drivers propose to me.”

Marilyn K., college president: “I don’t believe I’m looking for friends, but people call me a friend. I call people and say, ‘I love you,’ and I mean it because I love people easily. But friends? I don’t have many friends. I don’t think I am looking for friends. I am looking for connections. And I am really good at that because I know how to achieve common ground with people.”

Anna G., nurse: “I think I am a little shy sometimes. Usually I won’t make the first step out. But I do know how to put people at ease. A lot of my job is just humor. If the patient is not very receptive, my role becomes that of a stand-up comedian. I’ll say to an eighty-year-old patient, ‘Hi, you handsome guy. Sit up. Let me get your shirt off. That’s good. Take your shirt off. Whoa, what a chest on this man!’ With kids, you have to start very slowly and say something like, ‘How old are you?’ If they say, ‘Ten,’ then I say, ‘Really? When I was your age, I was eleven’ — silly stuff like that to break the ice.”

#### SELF-ASSURANCE SOUNDS LIKE THIS:

James K., salesman: “I never second-guess myself. Whether I am buying a birthday present or a house, when I make my decision, it feels to me as if I had no choice. There was only one decision to make, and I made it. It’s easy for me to sleep at night. My gut is final, loud, and very persuasive.”

Pam D., public service executive: “I was raised on a remote farm in Idaho, and I attended a small rural school. One day, I returned home from school and announced to my mother that I was changing schools. Earlier in the day, my teacher had explained that our school had too many kids and that three kids would have to move to a different school. I thought about it for a moment, liked the idea of meeting new people, and decided I would be one of them — even though it meant getting up half an hour earlier and traveling farther on the bus. I was five years old.”

Deborah C., ER nurse: “If we have a death in the ER, people call on me to deal with the family because of my confidence. Just yesterday, we had a problem with a young psychotic girl who was screaming that the devil was inside her. The other nurses were afraid, but I knew what to do. I went in and said, ‘Kate, come on, lie back. Let’s say the Baruch. It’s a Jewish prayer. It goes like this: Baruch Atah Adonai, Eloheinu

Melech Haolam.’ She responded, ‘Say it slowly so that I can say it back to you.’ I did, and then she said it back to me slowly. She wasn’t Jewish, but this calm came over her. She dropped back against her pillow and said, ‘Thank you. That’s all I needed.’”

### IDEATION SOUNDS LIKE THIS:

Mark B., writer: “My mind works by finding connections between things. When I was hunting down the Mona Lisa in the Louvre museum, I turned a corner and was blinded by the flashing of a thousand cameras snapping the tiny picture. For some reason, I stored that visual image away. Then I noticed a ‘No Flash Photography’ sign, and I stored that away too. I thought it was odd because I remembered reading that flash photography can harm paintings. Then about six months later, I read that the Mona Lisa has been stolen at least twice in this century. And suddenly I put it all together. The only explanation for all these facts is that the real Mona Lisa is not on display in the Louvre. The real Mona Lisa has been stolen, and the museum, afraid to admit their carelessness, has installed a fake. I don’t know if it’s true, of course, but what a great story.”

Andrea H., interior designer: “I have the kind of mind where everything has to fit together or I start to feel very odd. For me, every piece of furniture represents an idea. It serves a discrete function both independently and in concert with every other piece. The ‘idea’ of each piece is so powerful in my mind, it must be obeyed. If I am sitting in a room where the chairs are somehow not fulfilling their discrete function — they’re the wrong kind of chairs or they’re facing the wrong way or they’re pushed up too close to the coffee table — I find myself getting physically uncomfortable and mentally distracted. Later, I won’t be able to get it out of my mind. I’ll find myself awake at 3:00 a.m., and I walk through the person’s house in my mind’s eye, rearranging the furniture and repainting the walls. This started happening when I was very young, say seven years old.”

### EMPATHY SOUNDS LIKE THIS:

Alyce J., administrator: “Recently, I was in a meeting of trustees where one of the individuals was presenting a new idea that was critical to her and to the life of this group. When she was finished, no one heard her opinion, no one really heard her. It was a powerfully demoralizing moment for her. I could see it in her face, and she wasn’t herself for a day or two afterward. I finally raised the issue with her and used words that helped describe how she was feeling. I said, ‘Something’s wrong,’ and she started to talk. I said, ‘I really understand. I know how important this was for you, and you don’t seem like yourself,’ and so on. And she finally gave words to what was going on inside her. She said, ‘You’re the only one who heard me and who has said one word to me about it.’”

Brian H., administrator: “When my team is making decisions, what I like to do is say, ‘Okay, what will this person say about this? What will that person say about it?’ In other words, put yourself in their position. Let’s think about the arguments from their perspective so that we can all be more persuasive.”

Janet P., schoolteacher: “I never played basketball because they didn’t have it for women when I was a kid, but I believe I can tell at a basketball game when the momentum is changing, and I want to go to the coach and say, ‘Get them revved up. You are losing them.’ Empathy also works in large groups; you can feel the crowd.”

### INPUT SOUNDS LIKE THIS:

Ellen K., writer: “Even as a child, I found myself wanting to know everything. I would make a game of my questions. ‘What is my question today?’ I would think up these outrageous questions, and then I would go looking for the books that would answer them. I often got in way over my head, deep into books that I didn’t have a clue about, but I read them because they had my answer someplace. My questions became my tool for leading me from one piece of information to another.”

John F., human resources executive: “I’m one of those people who thinks that the Internet is the greatest thing since sliced bread. I used to feel so frustrated, but now if I want to know what the stock market is doing in a certain area or the rules of a certain game or what the GNP of Spain is or other different things, I just go to the computer, start looking, and eventually find it.”

Kevin F., salesperson: “I am amazed at some of the garbage that collects in my mind, and I love playing Jeopardy and Trivial Pursuit and anything like that. I don’t mind throwing things away as long as they’re material things, but I hate wasting knowledge or accumulated knowledge or not being able to read something fully if I enjoy it.”

### COMMUNICATION SOUNDS LIKE THIS:

Sheila K., general manager of a theme park: “Stories are the best way to make my point. Yesterday I wanted to show my executive committee the impact we can have on our guests, so I shared this story with them: One of our employees brought her father to the flag-raising ceremony we have for Veterans Day here at the theme park. He was disabled during World War II, and he now has a rare form of cancer and has had a lot of surgery. He’s dying. At the start of the ceremony, one of our employees said to the group, ‘This man is a World War II veteran. Can we give him a hand?’ Everybody cheered, and his daughter started crying. Her dad took off his hat. He never takes off his hat because of the scars on his head from the war and the cancer surgery, but when the national anthem started, he took off his hat and bowed his head. His daughter told me later that it was the best day he’s had in years.”

Tom P., banking executive: “My most recent client thought that the flow of capital toward Internet stocks was just a passing phase. I tried using a rational argument to change his mind, but he couldn’t or wouldn’t be convinced. In the end, as I often do when faced with a client in denial, I resorted to imagery. I told him that he was like a person sitting on a beach with his back to the sea. The Internet was like a fast-rising tide. No matter how comfortable he felt right now, the tide was rising with each crashing wave, and very soon,

one of those waves would come crashing down over his head and engulf him. He got the point.”

Margret D., marketing director: “I once read a book about giving speeches that gave two suggestions: Talk only about things you’re really passionate about, and always use personal examples. I immediately started doing that, and I found lots of stories because I have kids and grandkids and a husband. I build my stories around my personal experiences because everyone can relate to them.”

### LEARNER SOUNDS LIKE THIS:

Annie M., managing editor: “I get antsy when I am not learning something. Last year, although I was enjoying my work, I didn’t feel as though I was learning enough. So I took up tap dancing. It sounds strange, doesn’t it? I know I am never going to perform or anything, but I enjoy focusing on the technical skill of tapping, getting a little better each week, and moving up from the beginners’ class to the intermediate class. That was a kick.”

Miles A., operations manager: “When I was seven years old, my teachers would tell my parents, ‘Miles isn’t the most intelligent boy in the school, but he’s a sponge for learning, and he’ll probably go really far because he will push himself and continually be grasping new things.’ Right now, I am just starting a course in business-travel Spanish. I know it is probably too ambitious to think I could learn conversational Spanish and become totally proficient in that language, but I at least want to be able to travel there and know the language.”

Tim S., coach for executives: “One of my clients is so inquisitive that it drives him crazy because he can’t do everything he wants to. I’m different. I am not curious in that broad sense. I prefer to go into greater depth with things so that I can become competent in them and then use them at work. For example, recently one of my clients wanted me to travel with him to Nice, France, for a business engagement. So I started reading up on the region, buying books, and checking the Internet. It was all interesting and I enjoyed the study, but I wouldn’t have done any of it if I wasn’t going to be traveling there for work.”

### ADAPTABILITY SOUNDS LIKE THIS:

Marie T., television producer: “I love live TV because you never know what is going to happen. One minute, I might be putting together a segment on the best teenage holiday gifts, and the next, I will be doing the pre-interview for a presidential candidate. I guess I have always been this way. I live in the moment. If someone asks me, ‘What are you doing tomorrow?’ my answer is always, ‘I don’t know. Depends what I’m in the mood for.’ I drive my boyfriend crazy because he’ll plan for us to go to the antique market on Sunday afternoon, and then right at the last minute, I’ll change my mind and say, ‘Nah, let’s go home and read the Sunday papers.’ Annoying, right? Yeah, but on the positive side, it does mean that I’m up for anything.”

Linda G., project manager: “Where I work, I am the calmest person I know. When someone comes in and

says, ‘We didn’t plan right. We need this turned around by tomorrow,’ my colleagues seem to tense up and freeze. Somehow that doesn’t happen to me. I like that pressure, that need for instant response. It makes me feel alive.”

Peter F., corporate trainer: “I think I deal with life better than most people. Last week, I found that my car window had been smashed and the stereo stolen. I was annoyed, of course, but it didn’t throw me off my day one bit. I just cleared it, mentally moved on, and went right on with the other things I had to get done that day.”

## QUESTIONS

1. Talk to friends or coworkers to hear how they have used their talents to achieve.
2. How will you use your talents to achieve?



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